

ICC RANKING: **3rd**

**BEST WC PERFORMANCE
RUNNER-UP (2005, 2017)**

STRENGTHS

India enters the 2025 ODI World Cup with a formidable batting order. Form in this ICC Women's Championship cycle reflects consistency too — 24 games played, 18 wins, five losses and one tie. Shafali Verma's axing has forced Smriti Mandhana to unlock a new attacking gear, much to her opponents' chagrin. India has shown that it can up the tempo at will and has been able to post scores of 300-plus with ease. India also has one of the strongest spin attacks in this World Cup, with the experienced Deepti Sharma, Sneh Rana, and gutsy youngsters like N. Sree Charani in the ranks.

WEAKNESSES

Despite developing a promising pace-bowling unit, India remains somewhat thin in the seam department. Renuka Singh's return from injury brings with it the inevitable concern of ring rust. Arundhati Reddy is diligent but can be expensive, while Amanjot Kaur still carries fitness concerns. Kranti Goud has been a revelation, yet none of these options offers India the reassurance of genuine express pace.

OPPORTUNITIES

Smriti's purple patch bodes well for India ahead of the home World Cup. Her century against Australia in India's last bilateral before the tournament saw her bring an uncharacteristic T20-esque brutality to One-Day batting, which makes India's batting look twice as impregnable. This World Cup also presents Harleen Deol with the chance to make the number three position her own. If she can address her strike-rate concerns, she will add further weight to India's pursuit of its '300-plus in every ODI' mantra.

THREATS

While India's woeful fielding continues to pose problems, the bigger issue is its frequent inability to see plans through. Faced with a 413-run target against Australia, India began dominantly, with the Aussies gasping for air for nearly half the chase. But, as it often has in the past, India lost the plot. Add to that the pressure of a home World Cup, and there is barely any margin for error. Additionally, unfamiliar 'home' venues take away much of the advantage that comes with being a host.

PREDICTION

With balance across departments and home advantage, India should be among the frontrunners. A run to the final looks the most likely outcome, though how well the side handles knockout pressure will ultimately determine if it goes all the way.

Lavanya Lakshmi Narayanan



GETTY IMAGES

**CAPTAIN
HARMANPREET KAUR**

**COACH
AMOL MUZUMDAR**